



Beijing 2008

SHOOTING



AFP PHOTO / ISSOUF SANOGO



The Buddha Way

Bindra's coach on how she prepared the shooter for his gold pursuit

One of the key members of the team behind Abhinav Bindra is Swiss woman Gabriele Buhlmann. Five-time Olympian and European champion in rifle and small bore, Buhlmann is based in Germany and has been working with Bindra since Sydney Olympics. The trained psychologist says her work with Bindra is not focused so much on the mental side because "he is a young, wise man". In the last 18 months, the two have concentrated on finding a way to balance Bindra's left and right side again after his rehabilitation from the back injury and fine muscle coordination. In trying to recover, Bindra had to fortify his back muscles, focusing on strengthening one side for power and working on greater flexibility for the other. It meant adjustments in his firing position, the foundation of a shooter's entire skill. Buhlmann says, "Competitions are stressful and under stress, a bad position can collapse." Her motto then is to make a shooter's stance ideally balanced to its finest detail. Competitive shooting is, she says, the pursuit of a Buddhist truth. "The way is the goal, and in shooting, the technique becomes the way."

and as he went closer, she said, "First, you are first. Gold." "No," said the astonished Indian laughing, "no, no...". That's when he noticed the Indians in the hall. They were leaping, shouting, clapping and weeping.

The gold medal took a long time coming for a country that every four years stared its Olympian mediocrity in the face. The victory came just as the temperature began to rise on the Indians with four shooters, tipped for medals, failing to make their finals. The day after Bindra, two more, including Athens silver medallist Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore, went out of the Olympics, but the gold has kept Indian shooting on the map.

Accused of dominating the small stage and treading timidly in the company of giants, Indian shooters needed validation and Olympic gold has given it to them. It has given Bindra both reward and confirmation. In a 10-year-old career, he had done plenty. As the youngest Indian competitor at an Olympics, he narrowly missed out on the finals in Sydney and made the last eight in Athens, before winning the 2006 World Championship in Zagreb. Just when he should have been readying for Beijing, his back packed up due to the stress of hours spent in a 4 ½ kg shooting suit, hefting a 5 ½ kg gun.

Bindra set aside his gun for six months to re-build his back muscles. What emerged was what Buhlmann

described as the same shooter, "in another body". He re-calibrated his technique all over again which took him a year. For a year he concentrated on fitness and learning about Meridian stretching. "I can run for an hour-and-half now; earlier I couldn't run 10 minutes." Before you dutifully say "wow," Bindra adds, "but that doesn't mean I'm going to be shooting better."

He approached the Olympics with only one guarantee. That there really was none. "I did 99.99 per cent things right in Athens and didn't win a medal. I thought, what else can I do? What more?" Before Beijing he wanted to treat the Olympics like another competition. "If you think of the hype, the medal, your mind thinks of the Games as a dangerous situation. That's not good. The Olympics is a serious thing but I don't want to take it seriously."

In public, he speaks like he'd rather be undergoing a root canal without painkillers. In private, underneath that faintly bored exterior, which lazily gets called 'attitude', is a fairly typical guy, hooked on to the Internet and premium networking site ASmallWorld, who danced at his elder sister Divya's wedding and has close friends who know him for who he really is. A perceptive, intelligent fellow with nice line in self-deprecation. In Beijing, asked what he did for a living, he mouthed a silent "nothing much" as the question was being translated into Mandarin.